people, turning them inside out, sometimes rushing them for pace, sometimes going very far down the leg side. Occasionally, it moves in the air, but I don't really know exactly how I am doing that, it just sometimes does.

Mike Watkinson is playing for the first team and coaching the second team. I know Mike from afar, a Test cricketer who had adapted his game from a medium pace bowler to an off spinner and eventually earned England caps doing the latter at the back end of his career. He learned it as a league cricketer, running in as fast as he could until his body had not allowed him, reverting to off spin and then finding his way. The first time he'd seen himself bowl was the Benson and Hedges Cup final in 1984. He had played as a professional cricketer his whole life and never once seen himself bowl. He looked at himself on the television replay and wondered why he had a 20-metre run-up that he was doing at a right angle. Nobody had told him to do anything else. Mike learned so much about watching footage of himself just once that he had set up a camera to film the younger bowlers too. When I see footage of myself back for the first time, I am horrified. I don't see the good stuff – I have really good rotation, a rhythmical action and a natural illusion that creates the impression the ball is going too straight, always diving in at a batter, asking them to play at everything. I just think it looks horrible.

Mike is like a cricketing sensei. He watches me squirm a little bit, just at seeing my own reflection, and then asks a few uncomplicated questions. Some balls were going wayward and some were perfect, he said. We are playing a second team game at Middleton Cricket Club and in the first innings I've bowled more of the wayward than the wonderful, stropping my way back to fine leg and my mark like the world has caved in every time I do so. He only says a few words after the questions. He talks about the relationship between the index finger and the second finger. The pad of the second finger, he says, is where you want to be feeling the ball for the longest for the outswinger. Maybe try pointing that seam towards second slip, he says, too. The last thing that is in control of that ball is the tip of the finger, he tells me. That's where all the control is, just the feeling of it leaving the hand there. I do not know it yet but this is where, many years later, the deep calluses will have built up, after having felt that feeling so much, and learned to rely on it as my only real tell about how I am bowling.